

Chapter 112-2: Recognition

At this moment, the stage had changed to soft Wu dialect melodies from the Jiangnan region¹. Everyone quickly forgot the previous scene and closed their eyes to enjoy the music.

Only Chu Qingqiu was still staring at the opposite side. She didn't know why, though she felt certain it wasn't Ning Fuyi, she still found it difficult to look away.

The gauze curtains across from her had been completely pulled open, revealing everything inside. The woman seemed to be completely immersed in sensual pleasures. Besides the beauty in her arms, there were also three or four men and women in revealing clothes sitting around in the pavilion—some peeling fruits, others playing music for entertainment. It was quite a leisurely scene.

"Improper conduct," these words suddenly appeared in Chu Qingqiu's mind. She averted her gaze and tried to listen clearly to the content of the melodies on stage.

Just then, another knock came from behind her. Chu Qingqiu withdrew her gaze and said faintly, "Enter."

The door opened, and standing timidly outside was a young woman wearing a light blue silk dress. Her tightly bound sleeves had white ribbons hanging from them that fluttered gracefully with her movements.

She seemed very nervous, clutching a jade box in her arms: "This junior, Zhou Yantan of the Celestial Profound Sword Sect, pays respects to the Divine Venerable."

Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her, only lowering her eyes toward the lights outside: "What is it?"

"Reporting to the Divine Venerable, this junior has come on the orders of my master, Elder Songxiang, to present a congratulatory gift, celebrating the Divine Venerable's nirvana and resurrection. May the Divine Venerable enjoy good health and achieve great success in cultivation from now on." Though nervous, Zhou Yantan was steady in nature and spoke fluently.

After speaking, she didn't dare raise her eyes, her heart beating like a drum.

Only then did Chu Qingqiu glance at her. She had originally intended to decline, but remembering Elder Songxiang's age, she didn't want to be ungracious and said: "Set it down then. Please convey my thanks to the elder."

Zhou Yantan breathed a sigh of relief upon hearing this and hurriedly stepped into the pavilion, placing the jade box on the table and gently opening it.

However, the moment the jade box opened just a crack, Chu Qingqiu, who had been standing quite steadily, suddenly felt dizzy and fell forward while supporting her forehead. Zhou Yantan was alarmed and quickly stepped forward to support her.

However, in her panic, she accidentally pulled down the curtain beside them, so the lights immediately enveloped the pavilion, exposing the interior completely. Zhou Yantan quickly turned her head to avoid the blinding light, her face flushing red under everyone's gaze.

At the same time, she felt a sharp pain in her back. She looked up again and found herself directly facing two deep black holes in a mask at the other end of the lights.

The moment Chu Qingqiu fell, Ning Fuyi's waist had already left the chair back, but when she saw her being supported by someone else, she abruptly stopped.

The woman, with half her profile covered by hair, was still beautiful. She lowered her head covering her forehead, and from a distance, it looked like she was leaning on the young girl's shoulder.

Flames ignited in Ning Fuyi's heart, licking at her mind and burning away her composure. Ning Fuyi fiercely closed her eyes until the beauty beside her softly cried out in pain, finally bringing her back to her senses.

She heavily sat back in her original position.

If not for her remaining rationality, she really wanted to pull Chu Qingqiu out of that girl's arms right now, pin her down and interrogate her.

Interrogate her about whether she actually had feelings for her, why she had stirred someone's heart only to turn away coldly without looking back.

Interrogate her—didn't she dislike being close to people? Why was she now leaning in another young girl's arms?

Ning Fuyi's mind was in chaos from this evil fire, not even knowing what she was thinking wildly about. So she irritably picked up her wine cup and drained it, attributing the redness in her eyes entirely to the wine's effects.

Then she simply went all out and deliberately swept aside her sleeves, pulling the beauty to sit on her lap, lowering her head to bypass the beauty's palm-sized face and whispering in her ear, creating a scene of passion and allure.

"What, didn't anger them, but got angered by them instead?" the 'beauty' said gleefully in her ear.

"Shut up, stinking qilin²," Ning Fuyi said.

Meanwhile, Chu Qingqiu had already suppressed her dizziness. She quickly stepped back away from Zhou Yantan, then streams of white silk shot out from her sleeves, flinging the jade box out the door. There was a thud, and stones inside rolled around with clattering sounds.

"Divine Venerable, this..."

"What's inside?" Chu Qingqiu asked coldly.

Zhou Yantan was very panicked and stammered for a long time before replying: "Reporting to the Divine Venerable, it's... it's a Heartless Stone that master sent."

Heartless Stone, Heartless Stone—Chu Qingqiu almost raised her hand to shatter that stone, but finally helplessly lowered her hand: "Forget it. You may leave and take that thing far away. I can no longer cultivate the Heartless Way, and being near such an object actually harms my body."

Zhou Yantan was greatly shocked upon hearing this and quickly bowed to apologize before hurrying out to clean up the stone.

Chu Qingqiu sighed wearily. She slowly turned toward the outside. By now, no one was looking this way anymore. In the melodious tunes, the graceful figure in the opposite pavilion was surrounded by a circle of beauties, with another one in her arms, their postures intimate.

Chu Qingqiu had not wanted to pay more attention, but just as she was about to lower her head, an object faintly visible in the woman's sleeve caught her eye. She immediately felt as if a basin of ice water had been poured over her, cold penetrating to her bones.

That thing—she was all too familiar with it from both her past and present lives.

It was a prayer bead.

Footnotes:

1. **Jiangnan region:** A geographic area in China south of the Yangtze River, known for its soft Wu dialect and refined culture, particularly in areas like Suzhou and Hangzhou.
2. **Qilin:** A mythical creature in Chinese folklore, often called a Chinese unicorn, traditionally considered auspicious. In this context, it refers to Nine Infant (Jiuying) who has shapeshifted into the appearance of a beauty.